

Blue Mountains, New South Wales

Greater Sydney Region, NSW, Australia UNESCO World Heritage Area ECO Destination Certified

Last updated: May 2026

UNESCO status
World Heritage Area — 2000

ECO Destination
Certified — Ecotourism Australia

Bushfire recovery
Ongoing — post 2019-20 fires

NSW minimum wage
AUD \$24.10 / hr

i Destination overview

Australia's first ECO Destination certified by Ecotourism Australia & WWF-Australia — GSTC recognised

Size & scope
1 million hectares — the largest intact forest landscape on the Australian mainland. Comprises eight protected areas including Blue Mountains, Wollemi and Kanangra-Boyd National Parks.

Access from Sydney
80–110 km west of Sydney CBD. Katoomba is 2 hrs by train from Central Station — one of the most sustainable access routes of any major Australian destination.

Key towns
Katoomba (main hub) · Leura · Blackheath · Wentworth Falls · Springwood · Lithgow (gateway to Wollemi)

Best season
Year-round. Autumn (March–May) — spectacular foliage. Winter — crisp days, atmospheric mist. Spring — wildflowers. Summer can bring extreme heat and elevated bushfire risk.

Governing body
NSW National Parks and Wildlife Service (NPWS) · Blue Mountains City Council (ECO Destination holder) · DCCEEW (federal UNESCO reporting)

Key legal frameworks
NSW National Parks and Wildlife Act 1974 · NSW Biodiversity Conservation Act 2016 · EPBC Act 1999 · Blue Mountains NP & Kanangra-Boyd Plan of Management (updated 2024)

👥 Traditional Owners & Country

Traditional Owners
The Blue Mountains sits within the Ngurra (Country) of the Dharug and Gundungurra peoples. Six language groups have traditional connections to the Greater Blue Mountains area: Dharug, Gundungurra, Wiradjuri, Wanaruah, Darkinjung and Tharawal.

Key cultural sites
Red Hands Cave (Glenbrook) — rock art 500–1,600 years old · The Gully (Katoomba) — historically significant Gundungurra and Dharug summer camp, now protected · Echo Point Gathering Place — amphitheatre built in consultation with Dharug and Gundungurra Elders, overlooking the Three Sisters

Joint management
NPWS has established Aboriginal joint management arrangements for Blue Mountains and Kanangra-Boyd National Parks, with future expanded Traditional Owner involvement in the 2024 updated management plan.

For guides and sales staff: Always acknowledge Dharug and Gundungurra Country at the start of any tour. The Gathering Place at Echo Point provides an excellent purpose-built location for cultural orientation before viewing the Three Sisters.

! Sustainability challenges & current status

Bushfire legacy: The 2019–20 Black Summer fires caused devastating damage to the Greater Blue Mountains World Heritage Area. 99 animal species and 101 plant species were impacted. Over \$17 million has been invested in wildlife and habitat recovery. Ongoing restoration programs remain active.

Primary threats

1. **Climate change** — increasing bushfires, drought and temperature extremes.
2. **Invasive species** — feral cats, foxes, horses, cattle and deer.
3. **Visitor pressure** — concentration at key lookouts causing erosion and wildlife disturbance.

UNESCO monitoring

A State of Conservation report was submitted in December 2024 for review at the 47th session of the World Heritage Committee in mid-2025. The IUCN has previously rated climate change and bushfire risk as very high threats.

Positive initiatives

ECO Destination Certification (GSTC-recognised) · Blue Mountains City Council carbon neutral target (2025) · Rights of Nature recognition (2021) · Wildlife Recovery Mayoral Reference Group · \$3M federal investment in post-fire biodiversity restoration



Biodiversity & natural environment

Why it's listed

The Greater Blue Mountains Area contains the greatest diversity of eucalypt species of any comparably sized area on Earth. Ancient sandstone plateaux, deep gorges and temperate rainforests support extraordinary endemic biodiversity.

Wollemi Pine

Critically endangered — living fossil

Koala

Endangered — EPBC listed

Southern greater glider

Endangered — hollow tree dependent

Spotted-tail quoll

Endangered — EPBC listed

Brush-tailed rock-wallaby

Vulnerable — active recovery program

Gang-gang cockatoo

Endangered — bushfire impacted

Prohibited activities: It is illegal to pick, damage or remove any plant from the national park. All animals are protected. Do not feed any wildlife. All orchids native to NSW are legally protected.

✓ Visitor code of conduct

DO

- ✓ Stay on marked tracks at all times
- ✓ Carry minimum 2L of water per person
- ✓ Wear sturdy, closed-toe footwear for all walks
- ✓ Tell someone your planned route and return time
- ✓ Check fire danger ratings before walking
- ✓ Acknowledge Dharug and Gundungurra Country
- ✓ Visit the Gathering Place at Echo Point
- ✓ Use public transport (train) where possible
- ✓ Take all rubbish out of the park
- ✓ Purchase from local and Indigenous-owned businesses

DO NOT

- ✗ Leave marked tracks — cliffs are unfenced
- ✗ Feed any wildlife — illegal and harmful
- ✗ Pick or remove any plants or flowers
- ✗ Light fires outside designated areas
- ✗ Enter the park during Total Fire Bans
- ✗ Camp outside designated campsites
- ✗ Bring cats or dogs into national park areas
- ✗ Remove rocks, soil or any natural material
- ✗ Walk alone in remote areas
- ✗ Ignore park closure signs after rain

Cliff safety — critical: The Blue Mountains has unfenced cliff edges throughout. Multiple fatalities occur each year from falls. Orange Journeys guides must actively manage group positioning near cliff edges. Never allow clients to step over safety barriers for photographs.

Bushfire safety: Check NSW RFS (rfs.nsw.gov.au) before every departure November–March. On days of Catastrophic fire danger, national parks automatically close.

🏠 Local economic network & preferred operators

Indigenous-led Aboriginal Blue Mountains Walkabout — full-day immersive cultural tour through a rainforest gully along an original Songline. Includes body painting, bush food and storytelling. Led by Gundungurra guides.

Katoomba-based · Max small group · Highly recommended

Indigenous-led Buynyal (Sun) Tour at Scenic World — 90-minute cultural tour curated by Gundungurra man Uncle David King. Dreamtime stories, bush tucker, native flora and fauna.

Scenic World, Katoomba · Up to 12 people · Book in advance

Cultural Waradah Aboriginal Centre (Katoomba) — traditional dance and cultural performances by local Aboriginal communities.

Katoomba · Year-round · Cultural immersion

ECO certified Blue Mountains Adventure Company — canyoning, abseiling and hiking with qualified guides. Strong environmental practices.

Katoomba · ECO-certified operations · Multiple activity types

Sustainable transport

The Blue Mountains Explorer Bus connects all major visitor sites. The Sydney–Katoomba train is one of the most sustainable ways to reach any major Australian destination — actively recommend over private car.

Donation opportunities

Blue Mountains Conservation Society · Bush Heritage Australia · WIRES (wildlife rescue) · Blue Mountains Bushcare Network

↑ Orange Journeys engagement

ECO Destination advantage

The Blue Mountains ECO Destination certification is GSTC-recognised — the same framework that underpins Travelife. Reference this in client communications. ECO-certified operators within the destination have already been assessed against sustainability standards.

Conservation contribution

Recommended: direct a per-booking contribution from Blue Mountains packages to WIRES or the Blue Mountains Conservation Society, given ongoing bushfire wildlife recovery needs.

Positive story for clients: One of Australia's most progressive sustainable tourism destinations — carbon neutral target by 2025, one of the first regions to legally recognise the Rights of Nature, and a thriving ECO-certified tourism sector.

Sources: Blue Mountains City Council · NSW National Parks and Wildlife Service · DCCEEW UNESCO monitoring reports (Dec 2024) · Ecotourism Australia ECO Destination program · Visit Blue Mountains · Visit NSW · Blue Mountains Conservation Society · IUCN World Heritage Outlook · Fair Work Australia. Check NSW RFS (rfs.nsw.gov.au) and NPWS (nationalparks.nsw.gov.au) before every departure. Review and update at minimum every 12 months. Prepared by Orange Journeys sustainability team.